

But in America we routinely kick off with "what do you do?" When I was a Peat Marwick partner I often found myself in very short cocktail-party combats. They went something like this:

"Hi, I'm John. Harvard M.B.A., Citicorp, Park Avenue, Mercedes, smart shrink, pretty wife, jog, ski, read Shakespeare without cheat notes. How about you? What do you do?"

"I'm an auditor."

John would then spin on his heel and dart across the room in search of someone more fun to play with.

When people ask what I do, I say, "I'm retired." Some change the subject at that point, but few spin on their heels and walk away. For those who inquire further, I add, "I know I'm a little young to be retired. But except for my age, I'm retired in every sense of the word. I do all the things retired people do."

"What do you do?" really means "where do you work?" or "how do you make your living?" Those are tricky questions when you're retired. A 42-year-old retiree recently told me, "I don't tell people I'm retired anymore. They figure I lie around the house and eat all day. That's not my idea at all."

RETIREMENT, A FOUR-LETTER WORD?

In Buenos Aires one day I was sitting at the large lunch table at the American Club. One of the people at the table had just moved to Argentina, and a club member was telling him a little about each person there. "George Catson, to your left, is president of IBM Argentina. The next guy, Bill Fernandez, is in charge of production at Ford." And so on. But I noticed something curious when the host introduced the table's retirees. Eager not to offend, apparently, he introduced them with what I call "retired, but." As in, "Harry, there, was president of Kodak Argentina. He's retired, but he just opened an